



COAT COLORS

Although *Megaloceros* is often depicted with a rust-colored coat, cave art drawn by ancient humans who lived at the same time as *Megaloceros* tells a different story. These paintings suggest that *Megaloceros* had a more complex color pattern, which included a pale neck with a dark patch over its shoulders and a dark stripe running across its body.

Antler power

Megaloceros's large antlers may have been just for display, with females choosing partners based on the size of their antlers. However, recent research suggests that *Megaloceros* may have used them for defense or even in fights with rivals.

AT A GLANCE

- **HEIGHT** 6½ ft (2 m)
- **DIET** Herbivore
- **LIVED** 400,000–8,000 YA
- **HABITAT** Open grasslands



AMAZING ANTLERS

MEGALOCEROS

Sporting impressive antlers, *Megaloceros* ranged across the grasslands of much of what is now Europe and Asia. Although it is also known as the Irish elk, *Megaloceros* was actually more closely related to the much smaller modern-day fallow deer. Paleontologists used to believe that *Megaloceros* went extinct because its large and awkward antlers would have made it difficult for the animal to move around or graze easily. However, scientists now think that several different reasons, including competition for food with other deer species and a gradual change in the temperature of its habitat, may have caused *Megaloceros*'s extinction.